intends to be the hub of air traffic from and to the Southeast Asian markets.

Altogether, 13 projects, including the building of roads, hospitals, schools and solar power generation, worth Rs 24,006 crore, are being executed under various departments—finance, transport, roads, highways and public infrastructure, agriculture, environment and forest, housing and urban development, power, skill and employment and health and medical research. Assam's share of investment is Rs 5,027 crore, while the Centre takes care of the rest. However, in Sarma's governance model, more than funds, it's execution that makes the difference.

At the very beginning of his term, the CM set out to create an efficient bureaucracy so that his vision for Assam's growth could be implemented in the right spirit and with speed. Hard-working officers were identified, and even junior officers were given responsibilities of important departments such as industry and transport. Earlier, one senior officer used to handle multiple departments, slowing down the process. With independent responsibilities, officers were expected to deliver fast results and were made more accountable, with the CM directly monitoring the progress of every department.

That Sarma keeps long hours, attending to minute details, has these officers on constant alert. Principal secretary Sinha sleeps with a small diary next to him. "A call can come at 2 in the morning, and the CM will mention 8-9 ideas. Two months later, he may ask for a progress report on those ideas. At times, when I'm sleepy, I don't register the ideas properly and he gets upset if no work is done on his ideas. So, now I note down the ideas immediately," says Sinha.

Once the bureaucratic roadblocks were cleared, the CM focused on faster public service delivery by fast-tracking technological intervention in all the services under Assam Right to Public Service Act, 2012. So, the ambitious Mission Basundhara scheme was launched in October 2021 to not just digitise land records but also streamline and make all land-related services easily accessible to the public. After its massive success, the government launched the second phase in No-



SECOND TO NONE
The Bogibeel Bridge on the Brahmaputra in Assam

INDIA PICTURE

5 MANTRAS FOR SUCCESS



1

The chief minister keeps long working hours–from 8 in the morning to around 3 in the morning. He monitors the works of every department minutely, making regular assessment of progress and instant amends wherever needed. He doesn't keep any file for more than 24 hours without comment

2

He has made performance the principal policy of the bureaucracy under him. Efficient bureaucrats were identified and even junior officers were given charge of crucial departments such as industry and transport. Senior officers are no more burdened with multiple departments